The area designated as the Middle Sector is a vast region with varying topological variations. The Galwan River Valley forms the northern part, lying cheek by jowl with the western part of Aksai Chin. Part of the Shyok River Valley also comes under this sector, as do the Changchenmo and Qara Qash rivers. Then comes the massive expanse of Pangong Tso further to the south, separated from the Spanggur Tso by a mountain barrier. Another mountain barrier then separates the Spanggur Tso from the waters of the Indus, astride which lie Rezang-la and Tsaka-la. The Chushul airfield served as the supply base for the entire sector, allowing 114 Brigade commanded by Brigadier T. N. Raina to exercise control from both the logistical and operational points of view. The Tactical HQ of the brigade was established in the Chushul village itself.

As part of the Indian mobilization in Ladakh, 1/8 Gorkha Rifles commanded by Lieutenant Colonel Hari Chand was the first to arrive in Chushul in March-April 1961. Battalion HQ with Bravo Company (less one platoon that was sent to occupy Rezang-la) dug in next to the Chushul airfield while the remaining three companies spread out to occupy as much ground as possible. Alpha Company was headquartered at Phobrang, with a platoon each at Kongma, Changlung Valley and the Galwan Valley; Charlie Company also moved into the Galwan Valley while Delta Company occupied the northern and southern banks of the western edge of the Pangong Tso.

Despite the Chinese build-up on the other side, a year was to pass before 5 Jat began to arrive. A week after arriving in Leh, Battalion HQ along with elements of Alpha, Bravo and Delta Companies moved by surface transport to Zingral, the roadhead five kilometres short of Chang-la. Moving on foot from Zingral, the Jats tried to get to Darbuk, which in Ladakhi means the ‘gateway to hell’. The Chang-la crossing was a nightmare, with most animals transporting the battalion’s stores dying from sheer exhaustion and the bitter cold. This delayed the movement of the troops, but eventually more animal transport was commandeered and the Jats got across, all the men completely exhausted. After reaching Darbuk, the battalion was split up even further.

Bakhtawar Singh, along with the company commander of Bravo Company, Major Ajit Singh, met Raina in Chushul. While HQ 114 Brigade was at Leh and was looked after by Raina’s deputy, Colonel Karandikar, the Tactical HQ was at Chushul since May 1962. The task for 5 Jat, Raina